State Department's coordinator for Burma policy, would be nominated to return to the country as the U.S. ambassador. Part of the U.S. rationale may have been a desire on the part of the U.S. business community not to fall further behind the European community, which was taking similar steps to ease restrictions on trade and investment.

Businesses will still be restricted from having any dealings with the Myanmar military. The framework for sanctions is eroding. The restrictions in place on trade will keep the American export market out of the reach of Myanmar producers. Human rights groups are very cautious about the direction of U.S. policy. The ongoing conflict in the Kachin state has led groups such as “United to End Genocide” and Human Rights Watch to come out somewhat critical of the administration's policy direction. The human rights community believes that by taking such aggressive steps the administration has lost any leverage it had with the Myanmar authorities.

An additional step toward real change was the granting of a passport to Aung San Suu Kyi, which allowed her to travel abroad for the first time in 24 years. Suu Kyi addressed the World Economic Forum in Bangkok, Thailand, on May 31. She cautioned foreign investors against “reckless optimism” in dealing with Myanmar. The fanfare and hype surrounding her first foreign visit was overwhelming.

Suu Kyi's trip abroad did create turmoil back in Myanmar. Critics expressed concern that the trip was poorly planned and managed, with Thai authorities not updated about her itinerary and plans. Furthermore, the trip and comments made at different times to the press by Suu Kyi supposedly angered Thein Sein and may have created a rift in the important relationship. The press in Myanmar criticized Suu Kyi once she returned home from Thailand. Her lack of transparency during the visit as well as controversial visit to Tak province, home to a large population of ethnic minorities on the border between Thailand and Myanmar, was upsetting to the leadership. Thai authorities were concerned that the episode may have strained relations between the two countries. Clear evidence of a potential rift was Thein Sein's decision to cancel his trip to Thailand. He may have been worried about being upstaged by the Suu Kyi's visit, a concern that was of course quite valid.